

The Influence of English and Urdu Loanwords in Hindi.

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Hindi is one of the official languages of India and is widely spoken across the country. English, being a global language, has influenced Hindi speakers to a great extent. Similarly, Urdu, having been part of Indian society for many centuries, has amalgamated in day-to-day usage of Hindi. In this paper, we will briefly discuss how English and Urdu have influenced Hindi over time and how this change occurred.

This paper examines how loanwords from English and Urdu have entered Hindi, shaping not only speech but also thought processes. Hindi speakers use English in daily life: from chatting with friends and using social media, to reading Hindi stories that incorporate English words. Likewise, Urdu words in Hindi script have played a major role in art, particularly in movies, songs, literature and poetry.

What is a loanword?

A loanword is a word borrowed from one language and used in another, without translation.

Usage of English words in Hindi language

English arrived in India with the British East India Company in the 17th century and became widespread during the colonial period. (<https://www.britannica.com/place/India>)

Since then, English has remained in use in India, being one of the two official languages under the Indian Official Languages Act of 1963. (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Languages_with_official_recognition_in_India) English has influenced Hindi so much that English words are now included in everyday speech without conscious awareness. Even Hindi writers incorporate English words in their stories and articles.

These English words in Hindi speech or text are called loanwords or borrowings. Common examples include school (*for vidhyalay*), university (*for vishwa-vidhyalay*), train (*for railgadi*), road (*for sadak*), and expressions like please and thank you, which have replaced their Hindi equivalents (*kripya, dhanyawad*).

The list of English loanwords is extensive. Over time, Hindi speakers have started to forget certain Hindi words, replacing them with English loanwords. Certain modern terms, such as internet, fridge, and website, had no existing Hindi equivalents. Linguistically, these are still considered loanwords, as they were adopted directly and integrated into everyday speech.

Usage of Urdu words in Hindi language

Urdu developed in northern India around the 12th–13th century as a blend of local Hindi dialects with Persian, Arabic, and Turkic influences. Initially called Hindavi or Zaban-e-Hind, it served as a language for everyday communication among people of different linguistic backgrounds. By the 17th century, the term “Urdu” was used, meaning “language of the camp,” reflecting its role in military and administrative contexts. Urdu became a prominent language of administration, poetry, and culture in northern India, particularly in Delhi and Lucknow. Its rich literary tradition continues to influence Hindi, especially in literature, music, and everyday speech (<https://www.britannica.com/topic/Urdu-language>).

Although Urdu is not an official language of India, it is one of the 22 scheduled languages recognized under the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution, granting it official status in several Indian states, including Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Telangana, and Jammu & Kashmir (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Eighth_Schedule_to_the_Constitution_of_India).

Urdu is part of daily life, with words used without speakers realizing their origin. For example, *kitaab* (Urdu) corresponds to *pustak* (Hindi). Urdu words are particularly common in art, poetry and songs. Words, such as *ishq* (*pyaar*), *shukriya* (*dhanyawad*), *shayari* (*kavya*), *ashq* (*aansu*), and *mubarak* (*badhai*), carry a lyrical quality.

Linguistic Impact

English and Urdu loanwords have played a major role in contemporary Hindi. Their inclusion has enriched vocabulary, influenced linguistic structure (phonology, morphology, syntax, and semantics), and posed challenges for translation.

1) Phonology

Phonology is the study of sounds and pronunciation patterns in a language. When English words are used in Hindi, the sound pattern changes to suit Hindi speakers. The emphasis on vowels may shift, stress may move, and even silent letters may be pronounced.

For example:

Hotel: English emphasis on 'e'; in Hindi, pronounced ho-tal.

College: English Col-lege; in Hindi, Col-Lej.

Restaurant: English res-trau; in Hindi, res-tau-rant, written as rais-ta-ran.

These examples show that phonology adapts significantly when English loanwords are used in Hindi speech.

2) Morphology

Morphology is the study of word forms and their construction, including prefixes, suffixes, and inflections. Loanwords from English and Urdu often undergo morphological adaptation to fit Hindi grammar.

For example:

By train → train-se, showing instrumental case as a postposition.

Plural forms: *Kitabein* (books), *hotelon mein* (in hotels) illustrate changes in word structure.

Similarly, Urdu words also show adaptation. *Ishq-e* (of love) demonstrates the genitive aspect shifting to a postposition.

These examples highlight how loanwords are morphologically adapted, taking suffixes, plural forms, and grammatical markers to fit naturally into Hindi.

3) Syntax

Syntax is the study of sentence structure. English follows a Subject–Verb–Object order, while Hindi uses Subject–Object–Verb.

Examples:

English: "I read a book" → Hindi: "मैं किताब पढ़ता हूँ."

English: "I booked a hotel" → Hindi: "मैंने होटल बुक किया."

English loanwords follow Hindi syntax. Prepositions in English become postpositions in Hindi (e.g., in the hotel → hotel *mein*, by train → train *se*). Auxiliary verbs also move according to Hindi structure (e.g., "She is going" → "वह होटल जा रही है").

4) Semantics

Semantics is the study of meanings in language. English words borrowed into Hindi often undergo slight shifts in meaning.

For example:

Hotel: English – a place to stay; Hindi – also refers to a place to eat, particularly among older

speakers.

Show: English – a performance or exhibition; Hindi – includes TV shows and movie screenings.

Borrowed words may acquire new nuances, creating additional semantic layers. Urdu words, in contrast, generally retain their original meanings and are used in poetic, artistic, or formal contexts (e.g., bazm, aabru, qissa).

Translational Impact

Hindi has incorporated many English and Urdu loanwords into daily use. This presents challenges for translators.

English loanwords may have broader usage in Hindi, requiring careful selection of English equivalents. Translators must balance faithfulness to the original text with readability, ensuring retained foreign words do not confuse readers. Cultural sensitivity is important, as some loanwords carry connotations that do not translate directly. Technical terms and neologisms (internet, website, selfie, startup) may lack exact Hindi equivalents, requiring translators to retain, translate literally or provide contextual explanations.

Urdu words retain their meaning. Translators often keep them in literary works to preserve cultural and poetic nuances but must ensure comprehension for Hindi readers.

Successfully navigating these choices ensures that the translated text remains faithful, clear, and accessible, preserving both semantic accuracy and stylistic nuance.

Cultural and Social Influence: Conclusion

The widespread use of English and Urdu loanwords in Hindi reflects not just linguistic change but also the evolving cultural and social landscape. English words, incorporated into everyday speech, media and technology, introduce new pronunciations, word forms and meanings. Loanwords influence communication, translation and the expression of ideas.

Language evolves and adapts with its users, showing the deep interconnection between culture, society, and communication. The study of loanwords in Hindi highlights how language grows and adapts over time.

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Author's note:

1) This paper reflects only the author's own views and has not been peer-reviewed.

2) References

None beyond those cited in-text.

3)Note on originality:

The study of English and Urdu loanwords in Hindi has been discussed in previous linguistic research. However, this paper focuses on their phonological, morphological, syntactic, and semantic adaptations, along with the practical challenges of translating Hindi texts containing these loanwords into English. The examples and observations presented here reflect the author's own insights and interpretations, offering a unique perspective within the broader discussion.